



Noukclass.com

PSAC Exam Practice Platform — Specimen Paper

2026

History & Geography

Grade 6 — Primary School Achievement Certificate

Specimen Paper 1

Focus: Dutch & French Colonisation • Physical Geography of Mauritius

Duration: 1 hour 45 minutes **Total Marks:** 100

Candidate Name: _____

School: _____

Index Number: _____

INSTRUCTIONS TO CANDIDATES

1. Answer **ALL** questions in all sections.
2. Write your answers in the spaces provided.
3. This paper has **FOUR sections**: A, B, C and D.
4. Section A: Map Work and Physical Geography — 25 marks
5. Section B: History of Mauritius (Dutch & French Period) — 35 marks
6. Section C: Geography of Mauritius — 25 marks
7. Section D: Civics and Heritage — 15 marks
8. Read each question carefully before answering.
9. Marks for each question are shown in brackets [].
10. Do not open this booklet until you are told to do so.

SECTION A — MAP WORK AND PHYSICAL GEOGRAPHY [25 marks]

1. Study the map of Mauritius below and answer the questions that follow.

[10]

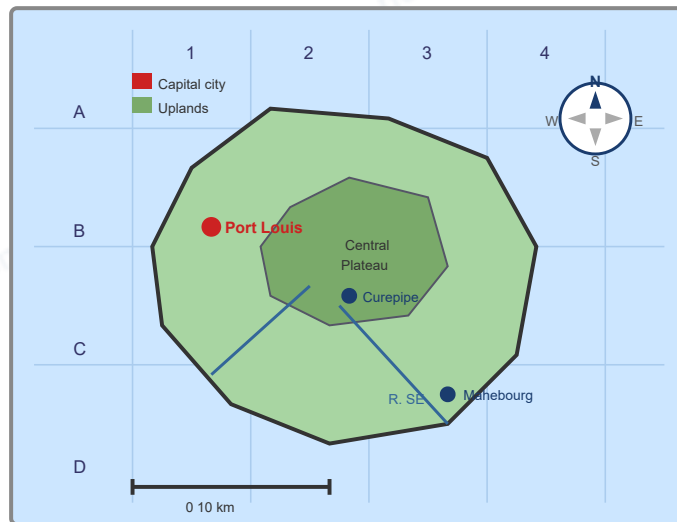


Fig. 1 — Simplified map of Mauritius (not to exact scale)

- (a) What does the compass rose on the map show? [1]

- (b) Using the grid, give the grid reference for Port Louis. [1]

- (c) Name the region shown in green in the centre of Mauritius. [1]

- (d) In which direction is Mahebourg from Port Louis? [1]

- (e) The blue lines on the map show rivers. Name **two** rivers of Mauritius you have studied. [2]

(f) What does the blue background on the map represent? [1]

(g) Using the scale bar, estimate the approximate length of Mauritius from north to south. Show your working. [2]

(h) Name the ocean in which Mauritius is located. [1]

2. Answer the following questions about the physical geography of Mauritius.

[15]

(a) Name the highest mountain in Mauritius and give its height in metres. [2]

(b) Tick ONE correct answer. Which of the following best describes the terrain of the Central Plateau? [1]

- ☐ A flat, low-lying area near the coast
- ☐ A raised, relatively flat area in the interior of the island
- ☐ A deep valley carved by rivers
- ☐ A sandy area along the beach

(c) Name **three** main physical regions of Mauritius. [3]

(d) What is a coral reef? Give **one** benefit of the coral reef to Mauritius. [3]

(e) Read the source below and answer the questions that follow. [4]

Source A

"Mauritius is a volcanic island rising from the floor of the Indian Ocean. The island has a rugged interior dominated by a central plateau, surrounded by mountain ranges and sloping down to coastal plains and a lagoon protected by one of the world's finest coral reefs. The island's rivers are short and flow rapidly from the plateau to the sea."

(i) According to Source A, how was Mauritius formed? [1]

(ii) Why are the rivers of Mauritius described as "short"? Explain using evidence from Source A. [2]

(iii) Name **one** feature mentioned in Source A that protects the coastline. [1]

(f) Give **two** differences between the coastal plains and the central plateau in Mauritius. [2]

SECTION B — HISTORY OF MAURITIUS: DUTCH AND FRENCH COLONISATION [35 marks]

3. Answer the following questions about the Dutch period in Mauritius. [13]

(a) In which year did the Dutch first take possession of Mauritius? [1]

(b) After whom was Mauritius named by the Dutch? [1]

(c) What does VOC stand for? What was the VOC? [2]

(d) Tick ONE correct answer. Which of the following animals became extinct during the Dutch period? [1]

- ☐ A Pink Pigeon
- ☐ B Dodo
- ☐ C Mauritius Kestrel
- ☐ D Aldabra Tortoise

(e) State **two** reasons why the Dutch found it difficult to settle in Mauritius. [2]

(f) Name **two** crops or resources that the Dutch exploited in Mauritius. [2]

- (g) Complete the timeline of the Dutch period in Mauritius by filling in the missing events. [4]

- **1598** — Admiral Wybrand van Warwyck lands in Mauritius; island named after _____
- **1638** — _____ (Dutch first settlement)
- **1658** — Dutch abandon Mauritius for the first time due to _____
- **1710** — _____ (Dutch leave permanently)

4. Answer the following questions about the French period in Mauritius.

[22]

- (a) In which year did France take possession of Mauritius? What did France rename the island? [2]

- (b) Who was Mahé de Labourdonnais? Name **two** important things he did for Mauritius. [3]

- (c) Tick ONE correct answer. During the French period, Mauritius was very important to France mainly because it was: [1]

- ☐ A A very large island with many people
- ☐ B A strategic naval base and supply port on the route to India
- ☐ C A place rich in gold and diamonds
- ☐ D The birthplace of the French king

- (d) Read Source B carefully and answer the questions below. [6]

Source B

"Under French rule, sugar cane cultivation spread rapidly across Mauritius. The French brought enslaved people from Africa and Madagascar to work on the sugar plantations. By 1810, there were over 60,000 enslaved people on the island, compared to fewer than 7,000 free settlers. The enslaved people had no rights and lived and worked in very harsh conditions. They were bought and sold like property. Despite this, many enslaved people resisted their captors, and some escaped into the forests of the Black River area."

- (i) From where were enslaved people brought to Mauritius during the French period? [1]

- (ii) Using figures from Source B, how many more enslaved people than free settlers were there in 1810? [1]

- (iii) Give **two** ways, according to Source B, in which enslaved people showed resistance. [2]

- (iv) Why do you think historians describe the treatment of enslaved people during the French period as unjust? Use Source B and your own knowledge. [2]

- (e) Name the important sea battle fought near Mauritius in 1810. What was the result? [2]

- (f) Name **two** lasting developments that the French left behind in Mauritius (think about buildings, institutions, or laws). [2]

- (g) **Essay question:** Describe the importance of Mahé de Labourdonnais to the development of Mauritius during the French period. In your answer, mention his background, his role as governor, and at least **three** achievements. [6]

SECTION C — GEOGRAPHY OF MAURITIUS [25 marks]

5. Answer the following questions about the natural geography of Mauritius.

[12]

- (a) What type of climate does Mauritius have? [1]

- ☐ A Desert climate
☐ B Tropical climate
☐ C Arctic climate
☐ D Mediterranean climate

- (b) Name the **two** main seasons in Mauritius and give the approximate months for each. [4]

- (c) Explain what a cyclone is. Name **one** month when cyclones are most likely to affect Mauritius. [3]

- (d) Why does the east of Mauritius receive more rainfall than the west? [2]

- (e) Name **two** natural resources found in or around Mauritius. [2]

6. Study the information below and answer the questions.

[13]

Source C: Population and Settlement in Mauritius

Mauritius has a population of about 1.3 million people. Most people live in towns and villages on the coastal lowlands and the lower slopes of the Central Plateau. Port Louis, the capital, is the largest city with about 150,000 inhabitants. Other important towns include Curepipe, Vacoas-Phoenix, and Quatre Bornes. The island is densely populated, with most agricultural activity taking place in the sugar-growing areas of the north and east.

- (a) What is the approximate total population of Mauritius according to Source C? [1]

- (b) According to Source C, where do most people in Mauritius live? Give **two** locations. [2]

- (c) Name the capital city of Mauritius. In which part of the island is it located? [2]

- (d) Name **three** other important towns in Mauritius apart from Port Louis. [3]

- (e) What are the main languages spoken in Mauritius? Name at least **three**. [3]

- (f) Suggest **two** reasons why Port Louis grew to become the most important city in Mauritius. (Think about its position and history.) [2]



noukclass.com

noukclass.com

nouk'

noukclass.com

noukclass.com

nouk'

noukclass.com

noukclass.com

nouk'

noukclass.com

noukclass.com

nouk'

noukclass.com

noukclass.com

nouk'

noukclass.com

noukclass.com

nouk'

SECTION D — CIVICS AND HERITAGE [15 marks]

7. Answer the following questions about national symbols and heritage. [8]

- (a) Describe the national flag of Mauritius. Name the **four colours** in order from top to bottom, and give the meaning of **two** of the colours. [4]

- (b) Tick ONE correct answer. What is the national flower of Mauritius? [1]

- ☐ A Rose
- ☐ B Boucle d'Oreille (*Trochetia boutoniana*)
- ☐ C Lotus
- ☐ D Hibiscus

- (c) Name **one** UNESCO World Heritage Site in Mauritius and explain briefly why it was given this status. [3]

8. Answer the following questions about the government of Mauritius. [7]

- (a) What type of government does Mauritius have? Tick ONE correct answer. [1]

- ☐ A Monarchy
- ☐ B Democratic Republic
- ☐ C Military dictatorship
- ☐ D Colony

- (b) Who is the Head of State of Mauritius? [1]

- (c) What is the role of the National Assembly in Mauritius? Give **two** functions. [2]

- (d) In what year did Mauritius become a Republic? Who was the first President of the Republic? [2]

- (e) Who is remembered as the "Father of the Nation" of Mauritius? [1]

End of Paper 1 — Check your work before handing in. Total: 100 marks.

Mark Scheme — Specimen Paper 1 (2026)

For teacher / parent use only. This mark scheme is a guide. Accept any reasonable answer that demonstrates correct understanding. Answers in brackets are acceptable alternatives. Award marks generously for responses that show understanding even if the exact wording differs.

Q	Answer	Marks
1(a)	It shows directions (North, South, East, West) / cardinal directions on the map	1
1(b)	B1 (accept any grid square that includes Port Louis on the northwest coast)	1
1(c)	Central Plateau	1
1(d)	South-east / SE	1
1(e)	Any two: Grand River South East; Black River; Rivière du Rempart; La Chaux River (1 mark each)	2
1(f)	The Indian Ocean / the sea / water	1
1(g)	Approximately 40–45 km north-south. Working shown using scale bar. (Award 1 for method, 1 for reasonable answer)	2
1(h)	The Indian Ocean	1
2(a)	Piton de la Petite Rivière Noire; 828 metres (1 mark each)	2
2(b)	B — A raised, relatively flat area in the interior of the island	1
2(c)	Any three: Central Plateau; Coastal plains; Mountain ranges / Black River Gorges; Northern plains (1 mark each)	3
2(d)	Coral reef = a ridge/barrier of coral rock built by tiny sea animals (polyps) near the coast (1). Benefit: protects coastline from waves/provides habitat for fish/supports tourism/fishing (1). Award up to 2 marks for clear explanation + valid benefit.	3
2(e) (i)	It was formed by volcanic activity / it is a volcanic island	1
2(e) (ii)	The island is relatively small; rivers flow from the central plateau to the coast meaning they have a short distance to travel (1). Evidence: "The island's rivers are short and flow rapidly from the plateau to the sea" (1)	2
2(e) (iii)	Coral reef / lagoon	1
2(f)	Any two differences: Plateau is higher/cooler/wetter; Coastal plains are flat/lower/drier/more populated/used for sugar; accept any reasonable contrast (1 mark each pair)	2
3(a)	1638	1
3(b)	Prince Maurice of Nassau (Maurice van Nassau)	1

Q	Answer	Marks
3(c)	VOC = Vereenigde Oost-Indische Compagnie (Dutch East India Company) (1); It was a Dutch trading company that controlled trade routes to Asia (1)	2
3(d)	B — Dodo	1
3(e)	Any two: Cyclones; poor soil/difficult conditions; competition from other colonies; rats ate crops; disease; hostile environment (1 mark each)	2
3(f)	Any two: Ebony wood; sugar cane; ambergris; deer (introduced); slaves brought from Madagascar (1 mark each)	2
3(g)	1598 — Prince Maurice of Nassau; 1638 — Dutch establish first permanent settlement; 1658 — cyclones / poor conditions / rats; 1710 — Dutch abandon Mauritius permanently (1 mark each)	4
4(a)	1715 (accept 1721 for formal settlement) (1); Île de France (1)	2
4(b)	Mahé de Labourdonnais was the first great governor of Île de France (appointed 1735) (1). Any two achievements: built Port Louis as capital; developed the harbour; built roads; set up sugar mills; organised defence of the island; created an efficient administration (1 each)	3
4(c)	B — A strategic naval base and supply port on the route to India	1
4(d) (i)	Africa and Madagascar	1
4(d) (ii)	60,000 – 7,000 = 53,000 more enslaved people	1
4(d) (iii)	Any two: resisted their captors; escaped into the forests (Black River area) (1 each)	2
4(d) (iv)	Enslaved people had no rights; treated as property (bought and sold); harsh living conditions; no freedom (2 marks for clear reasoning using source)	2
4(e)	Battle of Grand Port (1); French won / the French fleet defeated the British fleet (1)	2
4(f)	Any two: French Civil Code (Code Napoléon); Port Louis; French language; Catholic churches; French street names; sugar industry (1 each)	2
4(g)	6 marks: 1 for intro/background; 3 for achievements (at least 3 named); 1 for development of Port Louis specifically; 1 for overall assessment of importance. Accept any well-structured response showing knowledge.	6
5(a)	B — Tropical climate	1
5(b)	Hot and wet season (November to April) (2); Cool and dry season (May to October) (2)	4
5(c)	A cyclone is a powerful tropical storm with very strong rotating winds and heavy rain (2); most likely: January/February/March (accept any cyclone-season month Nov–April) (1)	3
5(d)	The south-east trade winds bring moisture from the ocean; the east coast faces the trade winds and the mountains cause	2

Q	Answer	Marks
	orographic rainfall (rain shadow effect on west) (2 marks for clear explanation)	
5(e)	Any two: fish/marine resources; sugar cane; basalt rock; fresh water; forests (1 each)	2
6(a)	About 1.3 million	1
6(b)	Coastal lowlands; lower slopes of Central Plateau (1 each)	2
6(c)	Port Louis (1); northwest of the island (1)	2
6(d)	Any three: Curepipe; Vacoas-Phoenix; Quatre Bornes; Rose-Hill; Beau Bassin (1 each)	3
6(e)	Any three: Creole; French; English; Hindi; Bhojpuri; Tamil; Urdu; Mandarin (1 each)	3
6(f)	Any two: Natural harbour (1); Strategic position on trade routes (1); Developed as capital during French period (1); Administrative centre (1)	2
7(a)	Colours in order: Red, Blue, Yellow, Green (2 marks for all four in correct order, 1 for 2–3 correct). Any two meanings: Red = struggle for independence/blood; Blue = Indian Ocean; Yellow = light of independence/new dawn; Green = vegetation/agriculture (1 each)	4
7(b)	B — Boucle d'Oreille (<i>Trochetia boutoniana</i>)	1
7(c)	Aapravasi Ghat (1): UNESCO status because it is the site where indentured labourers first landed / of great historical importance to world migration history (1+1); OR Le Morne Cultural Landscape (1): symbol of resistance by escaped enslaved people / important cultural landscape (1+1)	3
8(a)	B — Democratic Republic	1
8(b)	The President (of the Republic)	1
8(c)	Any two: Makes laws; debates government policy; approves the national budget; represents the people; holds government accountable (1 each)	2
8(d)	1992 (1); Sir Veerasamy Ringadoo (first President) (1)	2
8(e)	Sir Seewoosagur Ramgoolam (SSR)	1

Total: 100 marks • Nouklass.com Specimen Paper 1 (2026) • Not an official MES document.